

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

The Healing Process



Some years ago, I spent a week in a prominent hospital recovering from major surgery. Every day, I would stroll along the corridors—mobility was part of the prescribed therapy—and make a new friend. It was quite a revelation. I had imagined that hospital recovery wards would be depressing places with patients withdrawn, introverted and psychologically scarred. Not true. The scars were physical but the spirit and attitude were surprisingly positive. Surviving a crisis does that to people. I would pass by strangers in the corridor and they would stop and chat, introduce me to their friends and family, and display genuine warmth. In any other circumstances, that would not have happened. It was partly brought on by a shared experience but also the personality changes that come in the wake of a major catastrophe. Most people emerge as better individuals, more caring, more open to change, less inhibited about showing affection and appreciation and with a strong desire to be more active in the community and society in general. It's part of a healing process that extends to other crises as well.

Much the same has happened after the tragedy and trauma of Mumbai. I see parents hugging their children tighter than ever before, couples who had drifted apart getting closer, families bonding with greater frequency, and a widespread, even uncontrollable desire to make a greater contribution to society. Seeing the shocking images on national television, the vulnerability becomes universal and the immediate reaction is to make your life more meaningful and caring. Those horrific 59 hours made us all Mumbaikars but it also made us starkly conscious of our mortality and the urge to leave a legacy that is beyond mere material possessions. There is anger too, and frustration, but the more powerful emotion is a positive one. It helps if there is a common and visible enemy, in this case, a recalcitrant neighbour, but most individuals have emerged as better human beings,

willing to bond with strangers, make public gestures of solidarity and give more of their time and money and effort for a common cause. Sometimes it takes a tragedy to bring out qualities we never knew we had. The countrywide show of unity, resolve and involvement are unprecedented, but so was the act.

There is another positive side to the post-crisis healing. We become less class conscious. That was evident in the standing ovation the Taj Mahal Hotel staff received from guests invited to the reopening last week and also from the fact that not many could—or wanted to—hide the dampness in their eyes. We will not walk into a hotel or restaurant again without treating the staff with greater respect than we did before. Tomorrow, they could save your life. If the ghastly attack on Mumbai has any silver linings, these are the ones. And, if it takes moment of madness to make us a kinder, gentler, more equal society, then let the healing process be a long one.

SAURABH SINGH



THOSE 59 HOURS MADE US ALL MUMBAIKARS. IT ALSO MADE US CONSCIOUS OF OUR MORTALITY.

SIGNPOSTS

BOOKED: Vijit Singh, member of the Jaipur royal family, step-grandson of Rajmata Gayatri Devi for his alleged involvement in a road accident which



killed a girl and injured four others.

NAMED: Sonia Gandhi and Shah Rukh Khan among the 50 most powerful people in the world in *Newsweek* magazine's annual poll.

AWARDED: To eight-year-old Livina Sri, a Microsoft Computer Professional (MCP) Certificate making her the youngest recipient of the certificate in the world for successfully passing the global MCP examination.

WON: By golfer Jeev Milkha Singh, the Asian Tour Order of Merit and the Players' Player of the Year title, after he became the first golfer in Asia to cross the US \$1-mn mark in prize money

